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Physiographic Divisions of India

About 1-2 questions a paper. Three documented repeats: the north-to-south sequence of Himalayan ranges (RAS 2024), the peninsular peaks Anamudi and Doddabetta (RAS 2024) and the Aravalli statement set (RAS 2023 and 2024).

Indian Geography gives you about 5 questions in the whole paper, and this chapter is the map half of it. Nothing here is analytical. It is a place matched to a state, a peak matched to a range, a pass matched to a road. Learn positions and heights, not descriptions.

Physiography of India

Extent and position

- 8 deg 4' N to 37 deg 6' N
- 68 deg 7' E to 97 deg 25' E
- 82 deg 30' E standard meridian
- Indira Point
- Tropic through 8 states

Himalaya, north to south

- Karakoram
- Ladakh
- Zaskar
- Himadri
- Himachal
- Shivalik

Peaks

- Kangchenjunga 8,586
- Nanda Devi 7,816
- Anamudi 2,695
- Doddabetta 2,637
- Guru Shikhar 1,722
- Arma Konda 1,680

Passes

- Zoji La
- Rohtang
- Shipki La
- Nathu La
- Se La
- Lipulekh

Northern Plains

- Bhabar
- Terai
- Bhangar
- Khadar
- Punjab doabs

Peninsular Plateau

- Aravalli
- Vindhya
- Satpura
- Malwa
- Chotanagpur
- Deccan Trap

Ghats and coasts

- Western Ghats continuous
- Eastern Ghats broken
- Palghat gap
- Konkan and Malabar
- Coromandel

Islands

- Barren Island
- Saddle Peak
- Ten Degree Channel
- Kavaratti
- Nine and Eight Degree Channels

Where India sits – the numbers RPSC actually asks

Start with position, because half the easy questions come from it. India stretches from 8 degrees 4 minutes North to 37 degrees 6 minutes North, and from 68 degrees 7 minutes East to 97 degrees 25 minutes East. The country is the 7th largest in the world with 32.87 lakh sq km, which is about 2.4 per cent of the world's land area. The east-west spread is so wide that the sun

rises in Arunachal Pradesh roughly two hours before it rises in Gujarat. That is exactly why a single standard meridian was fixed.

- Standard Meridian of India = 82 degrees 30 minutes East; IST = GMT plus 5 hours 30 minutes.
- It passes through Mirzapur in Uttar Pradesh.
- It crosses five states - Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Andhra Pradesh.
- Tropic of Cancer crosses eight states - Gujarat, Rajasthan, MP, Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, West Bengal, Tripura, Mizoram.
- Indira Point in Great Nicobar (6 deg 45' N) is the southernmost point of India.
- Kanniyakumari (8 deg 4' N) is the southernmost point of the mainland only - read the word 'mainland' before you answer.
- Seven land neighbours - Pakistan, Afghanistan, China, Nepal, Bhutan, Myanmar, Bangladesh.
- Two maritime neighbours - Sri Lanka and Maldives.
- Sri Lanka is separated from India by the Palk Strait and the Gulf of Mannar.

Borders and coastline - the figures worth memorising

Item	Figure
Total land frontier	15,106.7 km
Longest land border with	Bangladesh - 4,096.7 km
Shortest land border with	Afghanistan - 106 km
Coastline (re-assessed)	11,098.81 km
Earlier official coastline figure	7,516.6 km
State with longest coastline	Gujarat - 2,340.62 km

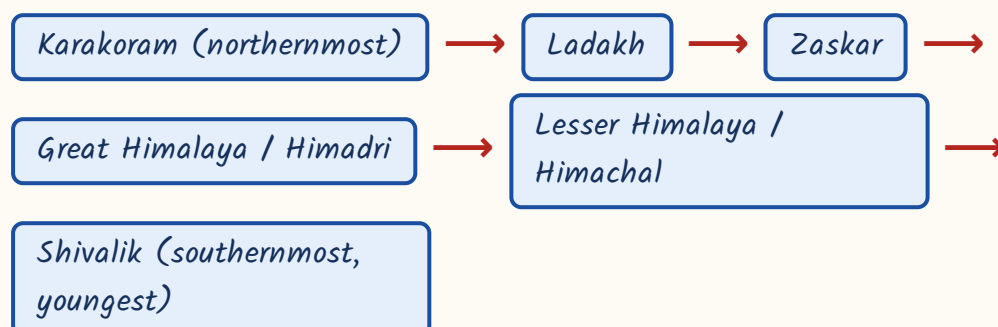
CURRENT LINK

Current link (as of September 2026): the coastline figure was re-assessed by the National Hydrographic Office to 11,098.81 km, against the long-quoted 7,516.6 km, because the newer survey follows the indented shoreline at a finer scale. Both numbers still float around in textbooks. If the option set contains 11,098.81 km, that is the newer official answer; if it does not, 7,516.6 km is what is being tested.

The Himalaya from north to south - the 2024 repeat

India has three geological divisions and they are of three different ages. The Peninsular block is the oldest - Archaean gneiss and granite, rigid and stable. The Himalaya is the youngest - folded sediments of the old Tethys sea, still rising. Between the two lies the Indo-Ganga plain, a trough filled with alluvium. Fix this three-way split first; everything else in the chapter hangs on it.

North to south across the Himalaya - learn this order



YAAD RAKHO

Trick to remember: Ka-La-Za-Hi-Hi-Shi. Karakoram, Ladakh, Zaskar, Himadri, Himachal, Shivalik. Say it downhill - you are walking from Tibet towards the plains, so the ranges get lower as you go.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - arrange Shivalik, Karakoram, Zaskar and Ladakh from north to south. Answer: Karakoram, Ladakh, Zaskar, Shivalik. The same paper also asked which range lies immediately north of the Great Himalaya. Answer: Zaskar.

The three main southern ranges

Range	Height	Marks of identity
Himadri (Great Himalaya)	about 6,000 m average	Carries all the great peaks; continuous
Himachal (Lesser Himalaya)	3,700 - 4,500 m	Pir Panjal, Dhauladhar, Mahabharat; hill stations
Shivalik	900 - 1,100 m	Southernmost and geologically youngest; unconsolidated

- Duns are longitudinal valleys between the Shivalik and the Lesser Himalaya - Dehra Dun, Kotli Dun, Patli Dun.
- Karewas are lacustrine (old lake-bed) deposits of the Kashmir valley, famous for saffron.
- Burrard's four regional divisions - Punjab Himalaya (Indus to Satluj), Kumaon Himalaya (Satluj to Kali).
- Then Nepal Himalaya (Kali to Teesta) and Assam Himalaya (Teesta to Dihang).
- Purvanchal hills - Patkai Bum, Naga, Manipur, Mizo (Lushai), Barail, Mikir, and the Garo-Khasi-Jaintia group.
- The Kaimur hills are NOT Purvanchal - they belong to the Vindhyan system of the Peninsular Plateau.

Peaks - and the trap RPSC set in 2024

Peaks are pure matching, so learn them as a height ladder with the state attached. Note the three careful phrasings the examiner uses. 'Highest peak of India' is Kangchenjunga. 'Highest peak lying entirely within Indian territory' is Nanda Devi, because Kangchenjunga sits on the border with Nepal. 'Highest peak in the Karakoram' is K2, which is higher than Kangchenjunga but lies in the Karakoram range.

Peaks by height, with the range and the state

Peak	Height	Where
K2 / Godwin Austen	8,611 m	Karakoram range
Kangchenjunga	8,586 m	Sikkim - highest of India, 3rd highest in the world
Nanda Devi	7,816 m	Chamoli, Uttarakhand - highest entirely within India
Kamet	7,756 m	Uttarakhand
Anamudi	2,695 m	Idukki-Ernakulam, Kerala - highest of Western Ghats and of peninsular India
Doddabetta	2,637 m	Nilgiri hills - highest peak of Tamil Nadu
Guru Shikhar	1,722 m	Mount Abu, Sirohi, Rajasthan - highest of the Aravalli
Arma Konda	1,680 m	Alluri Sitharama Raju district, Andhra Pradesh - highest of the Eastern Ghats
Dhupgarh	1,350 m	near Pachmarhi - highest of the Satpura
Saddle Peak	732 m	North Andaman - highest of the island group

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2024 - Anamudi, the highest peak of peninsular India, is in which state? Answer: Kerala. The same paper asked which hills Doddabetta belongs to. Answer: the Nilgiris.

TRAP

Do not write Anamudi as Tamil Nadu. Anamudi is in Kerala, where the Anaimalai, Cardamom and Palani hills meet. The highest peak in Tamil Nadu is Doddabetta. And the highest peak of the Eastern Ghats is Arma Konda, not Doddabetta - the Nilgiris are where the two Ghats join, they are not the Eastern Ghats. Peninsular ladder to fix it: Anamudi 2,695 - Doddabetta 2,637 - Guru Shikhar 1,722 - Arma Konda 1,680 - Dhupgarh 1,350; Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Rajasthan, Andhra, Madhya Pradesh.

Passes - a pass is a road, so learn what it connects

A pass question is never about height. It is about which state the pass is in and which two places it joins. Group them state by state and the matching becomes automatic.

Passes of the Himalaya

Pass	State / UT	Connects
Zoji La	Ladakh	Srinagar with Leh
Khardung La	Ladakh	Leh with the Nubra valley
Banihal	Jammu and Kashmir	Jammu with the Kashmir valley
Rohtang	Himachal Pradesh	Kullu with Lahaul and Spiti
Shipki La	Himachal Pradesh (Kinnaur)	India with Tibet; the Satluj enters India here
Bara Lacha La	Himachal Pradesh	On the Manali-Leh road
Kunzum	Himachal Pradesh	Lahaul with Spiti
Mana	Uttarakhand	Badrinath side with Tibet
Niti	Uttarakhand	India with Tibet
Lipulekh	Uttarakhand (Pithoragarh)	The Kailash-Mansarovar route
Nathu La	Sikkim	Gangtok with the Chumbi valley, Tibet

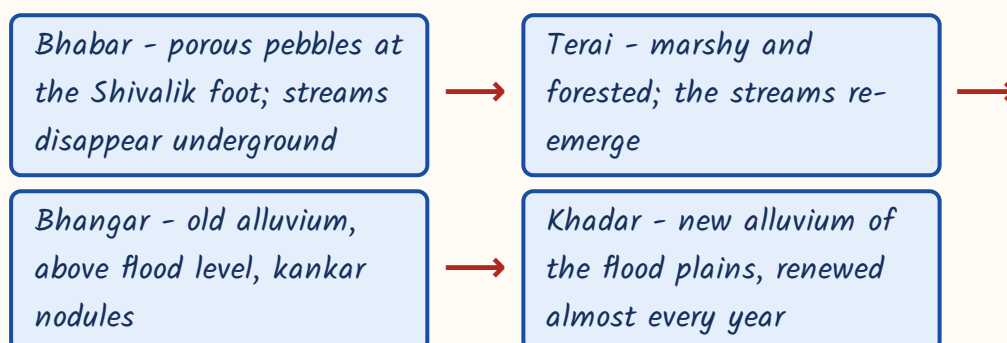
Pass	State / UT	Connects
Jelep La	Sikkim	Kalimpong side with Tibet
Se La and Bomdi La	Arunachal Pradesh	Tawang with the Assam plains
Diphu and Pangsau	Arunachal Pradesh	India with Myanmar

- Sort by state and the list stops being fourteen facts - two in Ladakh, four in Himachal, three in Uttarakhand, two in Sikkim, the rest in Arunachal.
- RAS has asked exactly this as a four-pair match: Shipki La - HP, Nathu La - Sikkim, Se La - Arunachal, Lipulekh - Uttarakhand.
- Zoji La is the one asked as a road link question - it joins Srinagar with Leh.

The Northern Plains - four belts, north to south

The Northern Plain is one long trough filled by the Indus, Ganga and Brahmaputra with their alluvium. Where the rivers leave the hills they drop coarse material, and further south they drop finer material. That single idea produces the four belts, and the belts are always asked in order.

The four belts of the Northern Plain, north to south



TRAP

Bhangar is the OLD alluvium that lies away from the flood plain and is not renewed. Khadar is the NEW alluvium of the flood plain and is enriched with fresh silt almost every year. RPSC swaps these two in a 'which statement is NOT correct' question. Bhangar has the kankar; Khadar has the fertility.

Punjab doabs, east to west

Doab	Lies between
Bist	Beas and Satluj
Bari	Beas and Ravi
Rechna	Ravi and Chenab
Chaj	Chenab and Jhelum
Sindh Sagar	Jhelum and Indus

- Doab names are built from the two rivers themselves - Rechna = Ravi plus Chenab, Chaj = Chenab plus Jhelum, Bari = Beas plus Ravi.
- The order east to west is Bist, Bari, Rechna, Chaj, Sindh Sagar.

The Peninsular Plateau and the two Ghats

The Peninsular Plateau is the oldest and most stable part of India - ancient crystalline rock, broadly triangular, tilted so that most of its rivers run east. Its edges are the Aravalli in the north-west, the Vindhya and Satpura across the middle, and the two Ghats down the sides. For RPSC the Aravalli is the highest-value item on this list, because it is Rajasthan's own range.

- Aravalli - the oldest fold mountain system of India, running north-east to south-west from Delhi to Gujarat.
- Highest Aravalli peak is Guru Shikhar (1,722 m), Mount Abu, Sirohi district.

- Malwa plateau lies between the Aravalli and the Vindhya.
- Dhupgarh (1,350 m) near Pachmarhi is the highest point of the Satpura.
- The Maikal range links the Satpura to the Chotanagpur plateau; Amarkantak is the source area of the Narmada, Son and Johilla.
- Chotanagpur plateau is drained by the Damodar; it is India's mineral heartland.
- Meghalaya plateau is cut off from the main block by the Malda gap, also called the Garo-Rajmahal gap.
- Deccan Trap is basaltic lava of Cretaceous-Eocene age; its weathering gives black regur or cotton soil.

ASKED IN RAS

Asked in RAS Pre 2023 and again in 2024 as a statement set on the Aravalli - it is one of the oldest fold mountain systems in India, it runs north-east to south-west, and its highest peak is Guru Shikhar in Sirohi district. All three statements are correct. Learn 'oldest fold mountain' as a fixed phrase; that is the wording the examiner reuses.

Western Ghats vs Eastern Ghats

Western Ghats (Sahyadri)	Eastern Ghats
Continuous wall	Discontinuous and broken
Crossed only through passes and ghats	Dissected by the east-flowing rivers
Higher - Anamudi 2,695 m	Lower - Arma Konda 1,680 m
Runs close and parallel to the west coast	Lies well inland of the east coast
Feeds short, swift, west-flowing streams	Cut by the Mahanadi, Godavari, Krishna, Kaveri

- The Eastern and Western Ghats meet at the Nilgiri hills.
- The Palghat (Palakkad) gap separates the Nilgiri from the Anaimalai hills.
- The Shencottah gap lies on the Kerala-Tamil Nadu border further south.

- Thal Ghat carries the Mumbai-Nashik route; Bhor Ghat carries the Mumbai-Pune route. Both are in Maharashtra.
- Hills to states: Cardamom - Kerala; Javadi - Tamil Nadu; Rajmahal - Jharkhand; Mukundara - Kota, Rajasthan.

TRAP

Bhor Ghat is in Maharashtra, not Karnataka. And note the Rajasthan hook in that hills list - Mukundara near Kota is the Rajasthan entry RPSC drops into an all-India matching set to see whether you are reading carefully.

Coastal plains and the islands

The two coasts behave in opposite ways, and that contrast is the whole question. The west coast is narrow because the Sahyadri comes right down to the sea, and it is a submergent coast - drowned, with lagoons and backwaters. The east coast is wide, emergent and deltaic, because the big peninsular rivers dump their load there.

- Western coastal plain, north to south: Kachchh-Kathiawar, Gujarat plain, Konkan, Kanara, Malabar.
- The Malabar backwaters are called kayals.
- Eastern coastal plain: Utkal (Odisha), Northern Circars / Andhra, Coromandel (Tamil Nadu).
- Chilika and Pulicat lagoons both lie along the eastern coastal plain.
- Barren Island is India's only active volcano; Narcondam is dormant. Both are in the Andamans.
- Lakshadweep is of coral origin, headquarters at Kavaratti.

Channels of the islands - a favourite match

Channel or passage	Separates
Ten Degree Channel	Little Andaman from Car Nicobar (Andaman from Nicobar group)
Duncan Passage	South Andaman from Little Andaman
Coco Channel	The Andamans from Myanmar's Coco islands
Nine Degree Channel	Minicoy from the main Lakshadweep group
Eight Degree Channel	Minicoy from the Maldives

YAAD RAKHO

Degrees go down as you go south: Ten Degree in the Andaman-Nicobar sea, then Nine Degree, then Eight Degree in the Lakshadweep sea. Nine separates Minicoy from India's own islands; Eight separates Minicoy from a foreign country, the Maldives. Higher number, nearer home.

REVISION RECAP

1. India: 8 deg 4' N to 37 deg 6' N, 68 deg 7' E to 97 deg 25' E; 32.87 lakh sq km; 7th largest; 2.4 per cent of world land.
2. Standard meridian 82 deg 30' E through Mirzapur and five states; IST = GMT + 5:30.
3. Indira Point is India's southernmost point; Kanniyakumari only of the mainland.
4. Tropic of Cancer crosses eight states; longest land border is with Bangladesh, shortest with Afghanistan.
5. North to south: Karakoram, Ladakh, Zaskar, Himadri, Himachal, Shivalik - asked in RAS 2024.
6. Himadri about 6,000 m; Himachal 3,700-4,500 m with Pir Panjal and Dhauladhar; Shivalik only 900-1,100 m.
7. Duns lie between Shivalik and Lesser Himalaya; Karewas are the lake deposits of Kashmir; Kaimur is Vindhyan, not Purvanchal.
8. Kangchenjunga highest in India; Nanda Devi highest entirely within India; K2 is in the Karakoram.
9. Anamudi (Kerala) highest in peninsular India; Doddabetta highest in Tamil Nadu; Arma Konda highest of the Eastern Ghats.
10. Guru Shikhar 1,722 m, Sirohi - highest of the Aravalli, the oldest fold mountain system of India.
11. Passes by state: Zoji La and Khardung La in Ladakh; Rohtang and Shipki La in HP; Lipulekh in Uttarakhand; Nathu La in Sikkim; Se La in Arunachal.

12. Plain belts north to south: Bhabar, Terai, Bhangar, Khadar. Bhangar is old and kankar-bearing, Khadar is new and renewed.
13. Doabs east to west: Bist, Bari, Rechna, Chaj, Sindh Sagar.
14. Western Ghats continuous and higher; Eastern Ghats broken and cut by rivers; the two meet at the Nilgiris.
15. Palghat gap separates Nilgiri from Anaimalai; Thal Ghat and Bhore Ghat are both in Maharashtra.
16. Deccan Trap basalt gives black regur soil; Meghalaya plateau is cut off by the Malda gap.
17. West coast narrow and submergent with kayals; east coast wide, emergent and deltaic with Chilika and Pulicat.
18. Barren Island is the only active volcano; Saddle Peak is the highest point of the Andamans; Kavaratti is the Lakshadweep headquarters.